

aggression by both, the security forces and LTTE. Government spokesman and media minister, Anura Yapa, says, "The government does not want to be a party to a non-functioning ceasefire agreement." He added that if the Tamil rebels were to lay down their arms, the Government could resume talks facilitated by Norway. But, say analysts, by ending the truce, the Government has virtually shown Oslo the door.

The formal ending of the truce on January 16, after the mandatory two weeks' notice, will be marked by the departure of the Sri Lanka Monitoring Mission—a 30-member band of Norwegians and Icelanders who had

and human suffering would be unacceptable. Although Indian high commissioner in Colombo, Alok Prasad, was the first to be informed by the Government of its decision, Delhi did not issue a formal communiqué. Prasad did, however, convey the message that Indian Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was likely to cancel a planned visit to Colombo to grace the February celebrations of the island's 60th anniversary of independence from Britain. Indian External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee was also quoted to have said that there could be no military solution to the separatist problem. He urged for political negoti-

rebel territory have taken a heavy toll of life and ended with the guerrillas wresting back land and regrouping seemingly stronger than before. Maintaining this level of engagement has placed a heavy burden on the country's economy, which has slowed down with rising prices and inflation running at around 17.5 per cent. This year, the defence budget jumped by 20 per cent to a record \$1.48 billion.

Ditching the truce may have cost President Rajapakse international support but closer home, he has won over a potential ally that could help his ruling People's Alliance win parliamentary stability. So far, Rajapakse



BIG KILL: Mourners (above) at the funeral of LTTE's military intelligence chief Charles (inset)



BLOOD ON THE STREETS: Central minister Dassanayake (inset) was killed when his car was bombed



reported on truce violations by both the sides. The monitors had no punitive powers, but it was widely felt that their presence helped deter excesses on both the sides while keeping the international community informed of the situation in operational areas. Both the Government and LTTE have come under fire for abductions, disappearances and murders. Now fears have increased of an escalation of human rights abuses. "The Government has finally shut the door on international involvement in the peace process," says political commentator Namal Perera.

In strongly-worded statements soon after the Government's announcement, Japan, the Scandinavian countries, the United States, the European Union, the United Nations and others warned that more violence

ations and implementation of a credible devolution package that would be acceptable to minority Tamils. India's concern was that while Rajapakse was dismantling an existing structure that addressed the peace issue, he was not putting in place a new approach.

President Rajapakse is no stranger to such disapproval. Far from letting it sting him, he has repeatedly said this will be a fight to the finish, especially after claiming several victories in the battlefield last year. Although analysts say the militants are taking a sustained battering on the battlefield this time, LTTE has shown in the past that it can strike back at any time and anywhere. Last year, it took the Government by surprise when its single-engine aircraft made debilitating raids on key military and economic installations. Previous military operations to reclaim

has managed to keep a shaky simple majority in place by engineering defections from the Opposition.

Now he has opened the way for the hardline nationalist Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna (JVP), a vocal critic of the Norwegian effort and the ceasefire agreement, to join the Government. With a sizeable 37 seats in the 225-member legislature, JVP could make the Government sink or swim. Jayadeva Uyangoda, head of the political science department, Colombo University, points out: "The Government is not at all interested in the international consequences of its action. The abrogation was politically expedient." The stridently hawkish JVP is all that Rajapakse could want for as a friend. But the Sri Lankan President has set his nation on a dangerous path of confrontation again. ■